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Polaris

Discover the constellations in your memories

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Problem



- People cannot perceive patterns in their emotional memories.
- We experience memories through sensory atmospheres such as sound, smell, temperature, place, and emotional tone.
  - Ex: Smell, sound, temperature, objects, atmosphere.
- However, most memory tools organize experiences chronologically
  - Ex: Photo albums, journals, timelines

This mismatch makes it difficult to:

1. Recognize patterns in emotional experiences
2. See connections between different life moments
3. Rediscover meaningful moments

Why This Problem Matters

- Nostalgia often acts as a subconscious coping mechanism
- People revisit certain memories when they feel...
  - stressed, overwhelmed, lonely, & disconnected
- These comfort patterns are mostly invisible

Interview Insights:

1. All 3 participants described nostalgia through sensory cues, not just facts or dates
2. Comforting memories were tied to family, safety, ease, and low-pressure moments

Wellness Goal

- Target Outcome: Improve emotional awareness and self-reflection
- *Polaris* helps users recognize patterns in their memories that are normally difficult to perceive:

1. Which sensory cues reliably soothe them
2. How emotional stress connect across life moments
3. What types of memories repeat

- To reveal these patterns, *Polaris* targets three dimensions of wellbeing:



Mental

Understanding emotional patterns in memories



Emotional

Encouraging reflection and self-awareness



Social

Highlighting meaningful relationships and shared experiences

Target Audience

- Young adults and college students navigating stress, transition, and identity

- For people who often:

1. Reflect on past experiences
2. Revisit memories for comfort
3. Want deeper emotional self-understanding
4. Feel disconnected or overwhelmed

- For people who need:

1. Emotional clarity
2. Understanding patterns in their experiences
3. Meaningful reflection
4. Identifying memories that support wellbeing

The New Sense: *Nostalgic Resonance*

- Nostalgic resonance is the emotional signal created when memories share similar sensory environments and emotional qualities
- It helps people perceive patterns between meaningful memories across time



What This New Sense Reveals

- Through nostalgic resonance, users can detect patterns in how their memories feel and connect across time, which are revealed through...

3 Visual Signals of Nostalgic Resonance

Visual Signal #1



Clusters

Emotionally similar memories

Visual Signal #2



Bridges

Connections across life moments

Visual Signal #3



Recurring Signals

Sensory cues appearing across memories

Instead of remembering memories individually, users can now perceive the emotional structure connecting them

Polaris in Everyday Life

Use Cases

1 Finding Comfort During Stress

- Jamie is having a stressful day at work.
- They open Polaris and explore memories tagged as peaceful or calming.
- Jamie notices a cluster of quiet outdoor moments and revisits those memories, helping them feel calmer and more centered.

2 Social Insight

- Alex wants to understand their social life better.
- They explore clusters of memories involving friends and family.
- Alex realizes relationships with certain friends consistently bring joy, helping them prioritize time with supportive people.

3 Personal Growth

- Sam reflects on a challenging period from a few years ago.
- They explore older memories in Polaris and see how these connect to later, happier experiences.
- Sam visualizes emotional growth over time and feels a sense of resilience and progress.

Solution: *Polaris*

- *Polaris* visualizes memories as a sensory landscape instead of a timeline
- Memories become stars in a personal galaxy, positioned by their sensory and emotional qualities
  - Colors ⟶ Emotion
  - Brightness ⟶ Nostalgia intensity
- Over time, the constellation reveals patterns such as clusters of emotionally similar memories, bridges between distant life moments, and recurring sensory signals.



We applied emotional color theory to map feelings to star colors - inspired by memory balls in Inside Out, allowing users to quickly perceive the emotional patterns in their memories.

Solution Positioning

1. **Emotion-Driven Memory Mapping**
   Visualizes memories through emotions and sensory cues, not chronological

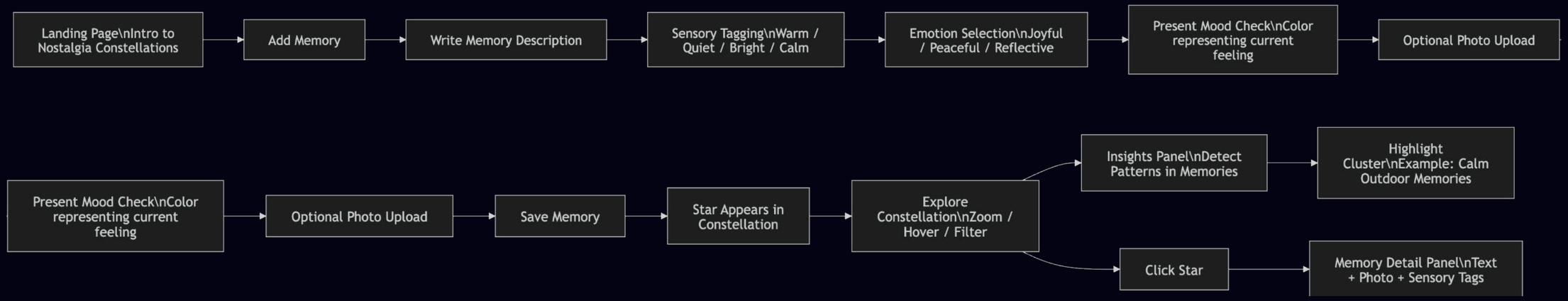
2. **Hidden Pattern Detection**
   Reveals connections between experiences that traditional journals or photo albums cannot show

3. **Nostalgic Resonance Awareness**
   Helps users perceive emotional patterns across memories and life moments

4. **Constellation-Based Reflection**
   Transforms memory from a linear timeline into an interactive emotional landscape

5. **Wellbeing-Focused Insight**
   Supports emotional awareness, reflection, and intentional reconnection with meaningful memories

User Flow Walkthrough



Flow #1: *Adding a Memory*

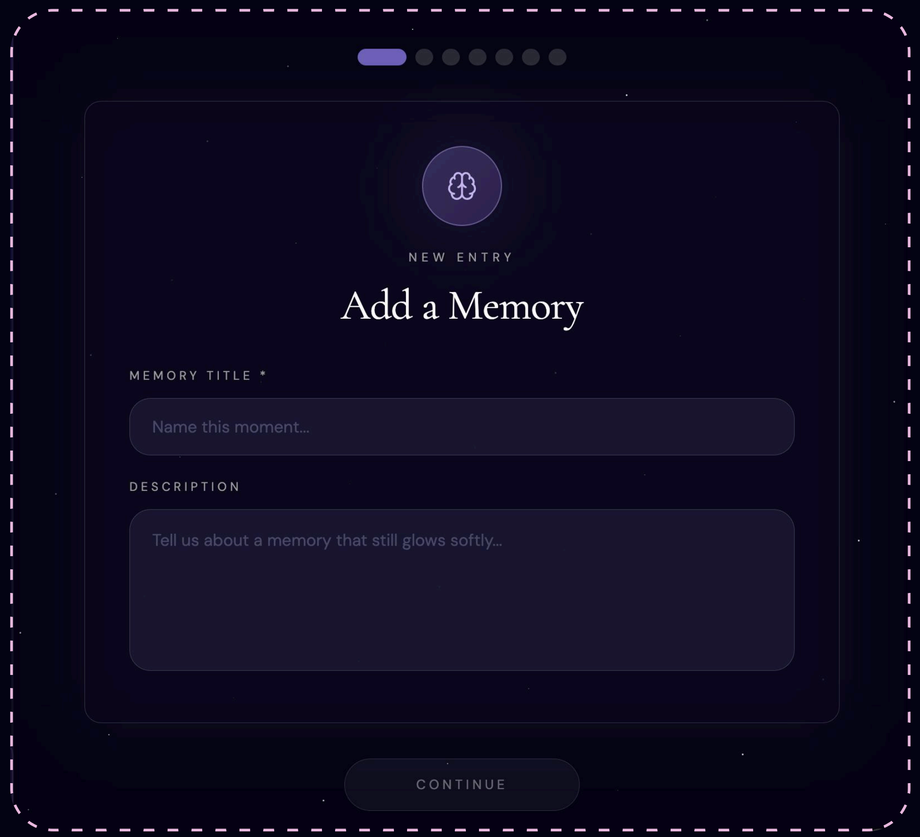
- Prompts users to reflect on a moment:
  “What’s the strongest thing you’re sensing right now?”

- They will then...

1. Enter memory details
   Title, short description, optional photo

2. Add sensory & emotional tags
   Sound, smell, weather, place, emotions
   → Feature: Sensory tagging of memories

3. Save memory ⟶ star is created in the constellation
   Color = emotion | Size = importance | Brightness = nostalgia intensity
   → Feature: Constellation visualization of emotional data



Flow #2: *Exploring the Constellation*

- Navigating the constellation is simple and intuitive:
  - Hover ⟶ preview memory summaries
  - Click ⟶ open the full memory panel
  - Zoom out ⟶ discover clusters and bridges between memories

- *Polaris* detects recurring emotional and sensory patterns across experiences

  → Feature: Pattern detection through resonance and insights



How Do Users Manage the New Information?

1. **Constellation Visualization**
   Memories appear as stars, allowing users to quickly see emotional patterns and relationships between experiences

2. **Interactive Exploration**
   Users hover or click stars to view sensory tags, emotional context, and detailed reflections

3. **Pattern Insights**
   Clusters, bridges, and recurring signals highlight meaningful emotional patterns without overwhelming the user

Safeguards & Ethical Considerations

1

Privacy First

- Memories remain private to the user
- No automatic sharing

2

Emotional Safety

- Users control what they record
- Sensitive memories can be deleted

3

Preventing Misinterpretation

- Insights are presented as reflections, not diagnoses

Polaris prioritizes emotional safety, user autonomy, and privacy when visualizing personal memories

Design Considerations

1

Usability

- Simple memory input with guided prompts & tagging
- Progressive disclosure to prevent cognitive overload
- Constellation navigation for intuitive exploration

2

Accessibility

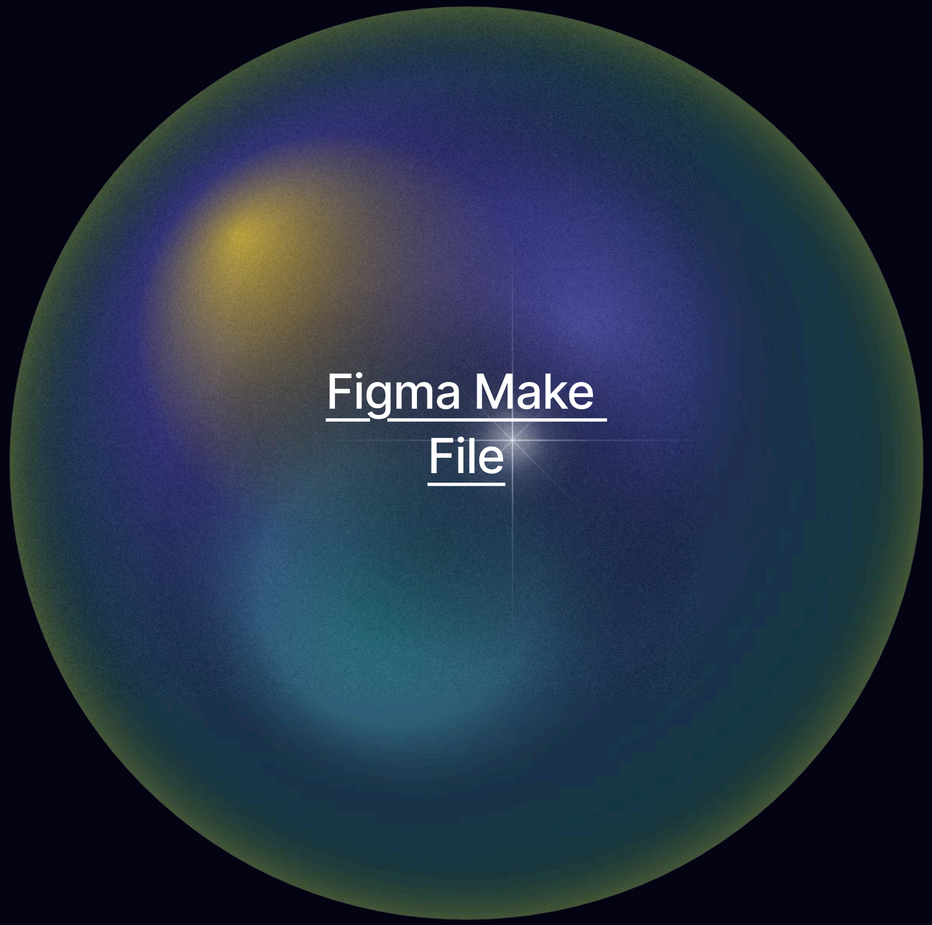
- High contrast & readable typography
- Color is supported by icons & labels, not color alone
- Optional reduced motion & zoom controls

3

Feasibility

- Web-based prototype built with scalable tagging architecture
- Memory stars generated from emotion & sensory metadata
- Pattern detection enabled through clustering & relational mapping

Figma Prototype



Thank You!